

From trunk roads, trade routes, *kos minars* (milestones), and *sarais* (inns), to waterways and irrigation canals, the Mughal Empire (1526–1761) witnessed considerable development in the transportation system for trade and administrative purposes. Even then, harsh weather conditions, especially during summers and the monsoons, posed great difficulties in movement, with the rivers often becoming unnavigable. Moreover, the chief means of transport remained rudimentary, comprising palanquins, country boats, bullock carts, and animals, such as horses, elephants, and cattle, due to which journeys were long, slow, and dangerous.

With the subsequent British occupation of the Indian subcontinent, most of the administration's attention was diverted towards political and military undertakings for territorial expansion. While no concerted effort was made towards new public works, even the erstwhile road network was neglected and reached a deplorable state. The breakdown of the transit system further fragmented the country into small towns, far from each other. Consequently, transportation of goods became expensive and impractical, trade collapsed, and prices and policies varied across different regions. In effect, goods could be moved through animals only to nearby places, eroding the demand–supply across the country.